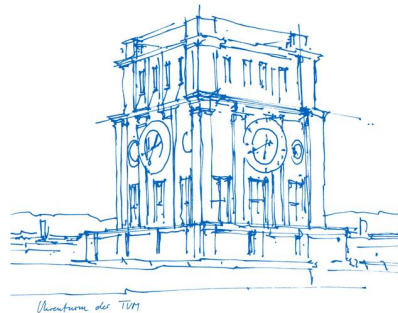


# PoreAccess-CO<sub>2</sub>: From Random Packing to an Interpretable Transport Closure

## Structure-resolved diffusion and adsorption in DEM-generated zeolite beds

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Good morning. This project is called PoreAccess-CO<sub>2</sub>. It examines how the random arrangement of particles changes CO<sub>2</sub> transport through a packed zeolite bed. The main aim is to retain information about the pore structure while developing a model that is much faster than a complete pore-network adsorption simulation. I will first introduce the physical problem, then explain the pore-network and one-dimensional models. Finally, I will show how we connect them through an accessibility-based transport closure and what the first twenty packing realizations tell us.



# Presentation outline

Motivation and research question

Model scope and physical mechanisms

Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

Results and robustness

Conclusions and next steps



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## └ Presentation outline

The presentation moves from the research question to the physical model, numerical methods, results and conclusions.

Presentation outline

Motivation and research question

Model scope and physical mechanisms

Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

Results and robustness

Conclusions and next steps

Section 1 of 5

## Motivation and research question

Why can similar beds adsorb differently?

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# CO<sub>2</sub> adsorption matters and packing structure is a missing scale



## Why CO<sub>2</sub> capturing matters?

- Food systems contribute about **one-third** of global anthropogenic greenhouse-gas emissions.
- Food and bioprocessing include recoverable biogenic CO<sub>2</sub> streams, for example from fermentation.
- Regenerable sorbents offer a compact capture and purification route.

**Novelty: connect random particle geometry to a fast bed-scale uptake model through a physically calculated pore-accessibility descriptor.**

## What is already established?

- CO<sub>2</sub> equilibrium and uptake kinetics on zeolite 13X are widely studied.
- Fixed-bed models normally use bulk porosity and a fitted effective transport coefficient.
- Random inlet-connected paths remain hidden inside that coefficient.

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└ Motivation and research question

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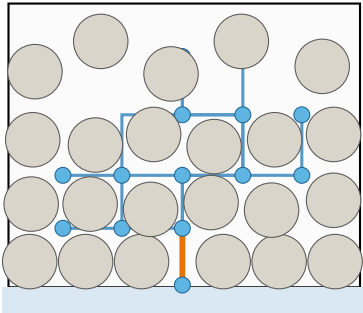
CO<sub>2</sub> capture and separation matter across many sectors. Food systems contribute roughly one third of anthropogenic greenhouse-gas emissions, and food and bioprocessing also generate concentrated biogenic CO<sub>2</sub> streams, for example during fermentation. Adsorption offers one possible route for capturing or purifying such streams.

The equilibrium behaviour and uptake kinetics of CO<sub>2</sub> on zeolite 13X have already received extensive attention. At bed scale, however, models usually represent a random packing only through its average porosity and an effective transport coefficient. That treatment hides whether the void space forms several open paths from the inlet or only a few restricted paths. Our novelty lies in connecting the random particle geometry to a fast bed-scale uptake model through a physically calculated accessibility descriptor.

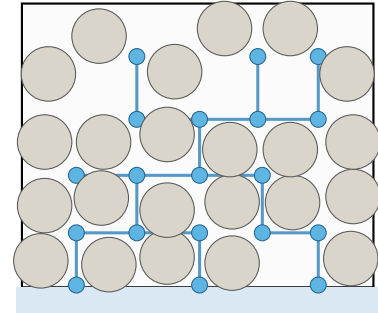
# Same porosity can hide different inlet-connected pathways

Can a pore-accessibility measure predict bed-scale transient transport better than porosity alone?

Packing A: inlet bottleneck



Packing B: multiple inlet paths



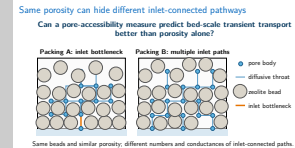
- pore body
- diffusive throat
- zeolite bead
- inlet bottleneck

Same beads and similar porosity; different numbers and conductances of inlet-connected paths.

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└ Motivation and research question

└ Same porosity can hide different inlet-connected pathways



This schematic introduces the central problem. The two beds contain the same monodisperse beads and can have almost the same total porosity. Their inlet-connected paths can nevertheless differ strongly. Packing A illustrates a network reached through one restrictive inlet bottleneck. Packing B illustrates several paths that connect the reservoir to the bed interior.

The blue lines show only simplified inlet-connected paths, not every throat in a real extracted network. The sketches are therefore hypotheses rather than simulation results. They motivate our research question: can a quantitative pore-accessibility measure predict transient bed-scale transport better than bulk porosity alone?

# Why zeolite 13X and what does the study isolate?

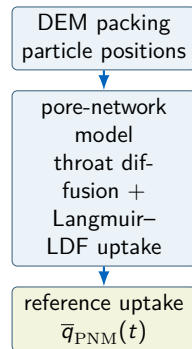
## Why zeolite 13X?

- established benchmark sorbent for CO<sub>2</sub>
- strong equilibrium uptake at low partial pressure
- commercial millimetre-scale beads form random beds

## Controlled model problem

- dry, isothermal, stagnant gas
- CO<sub>2</sub> enters from a reservoir below the bed
- pore-network model resolves throat diffusion and bead adsorption
- no imposed flow; no CFD

## How strongly does random void connectivity change access to the adsorbent?



## Motivation and research question

## Why zeolite 13X and what does the study isolate?

We use zeolite 13X because it is a well-established benchmark sorbent for CO<sub>2</sub>. It has strong equilibrium uptake at low partial pressure and is available as millimetre-scale beads that naturally form random beds.

The study deliberately isolates one mechanism. The gas is dry, isothermal and stagnant. CO<sub>2</sub> enters from a reservoir below the bed. We do not impose a gas flow and we do not solve CFD. We do, however, model the pore space explicitly. Starting from the DEM particle positions, the pore-network model resolves diffusion through the throats and couples it to Langmuir equilibrium and finite-rate adsorption in the beads. Its principal reference output is the mean network uptake curve,  $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$ .



Section 2 of 5

## Model scope and physical mechanisms

From particle arrangement to diffusion and adsorption

From particle arrangement to diffusion and adsorption.

# Twenty beds isolate variability caused by random arrangement



| Quantity                | Fixed value                |
|-------------------------|----------------------------|
| beads per bed           | 1850                       |
| bead diameter           | 1.6 mm                     |
| tube diameter           | 16 mm                      |
| $D_{\text{tube}}/d_p$   | 10                         |
| temperature             | 298.15 K                   |
| inlet $c_{\text{CO}_2}$ | 6.05 mol m <sup>-3</sup> * |
| simulation time         | 5000 s                     |

## Only the DEM insertion seed changed

- Delaunay–Voronoi networks were built directly from particle coordinates
- all networks were connected and spanning
- quasi-uniform Sobol sampling allocated pore volumes without a voxel grid
- transient and 1D models passed mass-balance checks

\* Approximately 15 vol.% CO<sub>2</sub> at atmospheric pressure and 298 K.

The ensemble tests arrangement effects under otherwise identical conditions.

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- └ Model scope and physical mechanisms
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The ensemble tests arrangement effects under otherwise identical conditions.

We generated twenty independent beds. Every listed physical and numerical condition remains fixed, including the number and diameter of the beads, tube diameter, temperature, inlet concentration and simulation duration. Only the DEM insertion seed changes. Differences between the cases can therefore be attributed to the random arrangement rather than to changed operating conditions.

We construct a Delaunay–Voronoi pore network directly from the particle coordinates. Sobol sampling means a deterministic, low-discrepancy set of quasi-uniform points. We use these points only to allocate the analytically calculated void volume among pore bodies. They do not create the network connectivity, and no voxel grid is required. All twenty networks span the bed and pass the mass-balance checks.

# Pore-network geometry and throat diffusion

## Network construction

- four bead centres define a Delaunay tetrahedron; its circumcentre is a pore body
- tetrahedra sharing a triangular face are joined by a throat
- topology comes from particle coordinates, not voxels
- $2^{22}$  Sobol points sample the solid and gas space.
- Gas-point counts allocate the calculated void volume to pores.

## Diffusion through throat $i-j$

$$G_{ij} = D_m \frac{A_{ij}}{L_{ij}}, \quad \dot{n}_{ij} = G_{ij}(c_j - c_i).$$

$L_{ij} = \|\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\|$  is the pore-centre distance. The irregular opening between three beads is approximated by an equivalent circular area

$$A_{ij} = \pi r_{ij}^2,$$

where  $r_{ij}$  is the clearance of the shared Delaunay face.

**The circular throat area is a geometric modelling assumption;  $G_{ij}$  has units of  $\text{m}^3 \text{s}^{-1}$ .**

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└ Model scope and physical mechanisms

└ Pore-network geometry and throat diffusion

| Pore-network geometry and throat diffusion                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Network construction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Diffusion through throat $i-j$                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• four bead centres define a Delaunay tetrahedron; its circumcentre is a pore body</li> <li>• tetrahedra sharing a triangular face are joined by a throat</li> <li>• topology comes from particle coordinates, not voxels</li> <li>• <math>2^{22}</math> Sobol points sample the solid and gas space.</li> <li>• Gas-point counts allocate the calculated void volume to pores.</li> </ul> | $G_{ij} = D_m \frac{A_{ij}}{L_{ij}}, \quad \dot{n}_{ij} = G_{ij}(c_j - c_i).$ <p><math>L_{ij} = \ \mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\ </math> is the pore-centre distance. The irregular opening between three beads is approximated by an equivalent circular area</p> $A_{ij} = \pi r_{ij}^2,$ <p>where <math>r_{ij}</math> is the clearance of the shared Delaunay face.</p> <p>The circular throat area is a geometric modelling assumption; <math>G_{ij}</math> has units of <math>\text{m}^3 \text{s}^{-1}</math>.</p> |

Four neighbouring bead centres define a Delaunay tetrahedron, and its circumcentre becomes a pore body. Two tetrahedra sharing a triangular face create two neighbouring pores connected by a throat. The indices  $i$  and  $j$  therefore refer to adjacent pore bodies.

Diffusion through that throat follows  $G_{ij} = D_m A_{ij} / L_{ij}$ . Here  $D_m$  has units of square metres per second,  $A_{ij}$  has units of square metres and  $L_{ij}$  has units of metres. Thus,  $G_{ij}$  has units of cubic metres per second. Multiplying it by the concentration difference gives the molar flow rate through the throat. The actual opening is irregular. We approximate it by a circular area  $A_{ij} = \pi r_{ij}^2$ . This equivalent circular area is an explicit geometric assumption of the model.

# Model scope and physical mechanisms

## Langmuir equilibrium and bead uptake

# Langmuir equilibrium and bead uptake

## Local equilibrium loading

$$p_k = c_k RT, \quad q_k^* = \frac{q_s b p_k}{1 + b p_k}.$$

## Finite-rate uptake

$$\frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{\text{LDF}} (q_k^* - q_k).$$

- $q_s$ : maximum CO<sub>2</sub> loading [mol/kg adsorbent]
- $b$ : Langmuir affinity [Pa<sup>-1</sup>], with  $bp_k$  dimensionless
- $p_k$ : local CO<sub>2</sub> partial pressure [Pa]
- $q_k^*$ : equilibrium loading at  $p_k$

## Meaning of the rate equation

- $q_k$  is the current loading of bead  $k$
- $k_{\text{LDF}}$  controls how quickly  $q_k$  approaches  $q_k^*$
- gas removed from adjacent pores is added to the bead

## Pore-network outputs

- pore concentrations  $c_i(t)$
- particle loadings  $q_k(t)$
- mean uptake  $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$

**Coupled diffusion and adsorption conserve the CO<sub>2</sub> inventory.**

| Langmuir equilibrium and bead uptake                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Local equilibrium loading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Meaning of the rate equation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| $p_k = c_k RT, \quad q_k^* = \frac{q_s b p_k}{1 + b p_k}$                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <math>q_k</math> is the current loading of bead <math>k</math></li> <li>• <math>k_{\text{LDF}}</math> controls how quickly <math>q_k</math> approaches <math>q_k^*</math></li> <li>• gas removed from adjacent pores is added to the bead</li> </ul> |
| Finite-rate uptake                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Pore-network outputs                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| $\frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{\text{LDF}} (q_k^* - q_k)$                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• pore concentrations <math>c_i(t)</math></li> <li>• particle loadings <math>q_k(t)</math></li> <li>• mean uptake <math>\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)</math></li> </ul>                                                                                      |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <math>q_s</math>: maximum CO<sub>2</sub> loading [mol/kg adsorbent]</li> <li>• <math>b</math>: Langmuir affinity [Pa<sup>-1</sup>], with <math>bp_k</math> dimensionless</li> <li>• <math>p_k</math>: local CO<sub>2</sub> partial pressure [Pa]</li> <li>• <math>q_k^*</math>: equilibrium loading at <math>p_k</math></li> </ul> | Coupled diffusion and adsorption conserve the CO <sub>2</sub> inventory.                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

Diffusion supplies a local gas concentration  $c_k$  around bead  $k$ . We convert it to partial pressure through  $p_k = c_k RT$ . The Langmuir equation then gives the equilibrium loading  $q_k^*$ . The parameter  $q_s$  is the saturation loading and  $b$  is the Langmuir affinity. Because  $b$  has units of inverse pressure, the product  $bp_k$  is dimensionless.

The actual particle loading  $q_k$  does not jump immediately to equilibrium. The linear-driving-force equation describes how it approaches  $q_k^*$ , with  $k_{\text{LDF}}$  setting the uptake rate. Gas removed from the pores is added to the particles, so the coupled calculation conserves CO<sub>2</sub>. The detailed outputs include every pore concentration  $c_i(t)$  and every bead loading  $q_k(t)$ . Averaging the bead inventory gives the reference uptake curve  $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$ .

Section 3 of 5

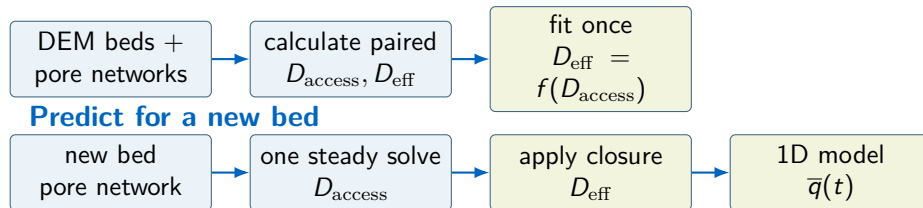
## Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

How we calculate accessibility and calibrate the reduced model

How we calculate accessibility and calibrate the reduced model.

# Development and later use are two different workflows

## Develop closure



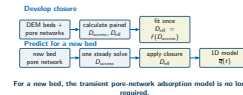
**For a new bed, the transient pore-network adsorption model is no longer required.**

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└ Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

└ Development and later use are two different workflows

Development and later use are two different workflows



This slide separates development from later prediction. During development, we run the full transient pore-network adsorption model for each training bed. From its uptake curve, we fit one effective diffusivity,  $D_{\text{eff}}$ . Independently, one steady network solve gives the accessibility diffusivity,  $D_{\text{access}}$ . The paired values across the beds allow us to fit the closure  $D_{\text{eff}} = f(D_{\text{access}})$ . For a new packing, the lower workflow applies. We still extract its pore network, but we perform only the inexpensive steady accessibility solve. The closure predicts  $D_{\text{eff}}$ , and the 1D model then predicts the complete uptake curve. The expensive transient pore-network adsorption calculation belongs to development and validation, not to routine use.

# The homogeneous 1D uptake model

## Axial diffusion and adsorption

$$\varepsilon_b \frac{\partial c}{\partial t} = D \frac{\partial^2 c}{\partial z^2} - (1 - \varepsilon_b) \rho_p \frac{\partial q}{\partial t},$$

$$\frac{\partial q}{\partial t} = k_{\text{LDF}} [q^*(c) - q].$$

- Solve both equations together for  $c(z, t)$  and  $q(z, t)$ .
- Use 100 cells and prescribed initial and boundary conditions.

**For every trial  $D$ , the 1D solver produces a complete mean uptake curve.**

## Quantity compared with the network

$$\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D) = \frac{1}{H} \int_0^H q(z, t; D) dz.$$

- Match the network's bed height, porosity and inlet condition.
- Use the same Langmuir parameters, LDF coefficient and initial state.
- Only  $D$  changes during fitting.

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- └ Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction
- └ The homogeneous 1D uptake model

The homogeneous 1D uptake model

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For every trial  $D$ , the 1D solver produces a complete mean uptake curve.

The reduced model replaces the irregular pore network by one axial coordinate. It solves coupled diffusion and adsorption in one hundred cells. The local outputs are the gas concentration  $c(z, t)$  and loading  $q(z, t)$ . Their spatial average gives  $\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D)$ , the mean uptake predicted by the 1D model.

The bed height, porosity, inlet condition, Langmuir parameters, LDF coefficient and initial state remain identical to those in the pore-network calculation. Only the diffusivity  $D$  changes. For any selected value of  $D$ , the solver must integrate the complete transient problem and return a complete uptake curve. This is why we call it a trial diffusivity at this stage. We do not yet know which value best represents the network.

└ Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

└  $D_{\text{access}}$  and  $D_{\text{eff}}$  answer different questions

| $D_{\text{access}}$ and $D_{\text{eff}}$ answer different questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $D_{\text{access}}$ : geometric accessibility <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>fix concentration at inlet and interior plane</li> <li>solve one steady, linear diffusion problem</li> <li>no adsorption and no time integration</li> </ul> $D_{\text{access}} = \frac{G_{\text{access}} H}{A_{\text{tube}}}$ <p><math>G_{\text{access}}</math> is total steady flux per concentration difference. <math>H</math> is bed height; <math>A_{\text{tube}}</math> is tube area.</p> | $D_{\text{eff}}$ : transient reduced-model coefficient <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>full transient network gives <math>\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)</math></li> <li>repeated 1D solves give <math>\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D)</math></li> </ul> <p>Define the curve residual</p> $e_m(D) = \bar{q}_{1D}(t_m; D) - \bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t_m).$ $\text{NRMSE}(D) = \frac{\sqrt{\sum_m w_m e_m(D)^2}}{\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t_f)}$ $D_{\text{eff}} = \arg \min_D \text{NRMSE}(D).$ <p>The trapezoidal weights <math>w_m</math> account for unequal time spacing and satisfy <math>\sum_m w_m = 1</math>.</p> <p><math>D_{\text{access}}</math> is cheap because it avoids adsorption dynamics and optimization.</p> |

These two quantities answer different questions. To calculate  $D_{\text{access}}$ , we prescribe concentrations at the inlet and at an interior plane and solve one steady linear diffusion problem. Steady here means that we directly solve the time-independent balance. We do not run a transient simulation and wait for physical steady state. The result is the total conductance  $G_{\text{access}}$  between the two boundaries. Multiplying it by bed height and dividing by tube area expresses it in diffusivity units.

$D_{\text{eff}}$  is different. It is the coefficient required by the reduced 1D transient model. The network first supplies  $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$ . We choose a trial  $D$ , solve the 1D transient model and obtain  $\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D)$ . The optimizer then changes  $D$  and repeats the 1D solve. At every saved time,  $e_m(D)$  is the difference between the 1D and network uptake. NRMSE combines these errors over the full curve. Squaring prevents positive and negative errors from cancelling, the square root restores loading units, and division by the final network loading makes the result dimensionless. The time weights account for unequal intervals. The value that minimizes NRMSE is called  $D_{\text{eff}}$ . This optimization explains why obtaining  $D_{\text{eff}}$  is more expensive than calculating  $D_{\text{access}}$ .

## $D_{\text{access}}$ and $D_{\text{eff}}$ answer different questions

### $D_{\text{access}}$ : geometric accessibility

- fix concentration at inlet and interior plane
- solve one steady, linear diffusion problem
- no adsorption and no time integration

$$D_{\text{access}} = \frac{G_{\text{access}} H}{A_{\text{tube}}}.$$

$G_{\text{access}}$  is total steady flux per concentration difference.  $H$  is bed height;  $A_{\text{tube}}$  is tube area.

### $D_{\text{eff}}$ : transient reduced-model coefficient

- full transient network gives  $\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t)$
- repeated 1D solves give  $\bar{q}_{1D}(t; D)$

Define the curve residual

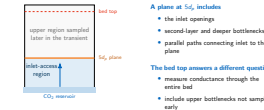
$$e_m(D) = \bar{q}_{1D}(t_m; D) - \bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t_m).$$

$$\text{NRMSE}(D) = \frac{\sqrt{\sum_m w_m e_m(D)^2}}{\bar{q}_{\text{PNM}}(t_f)},$$

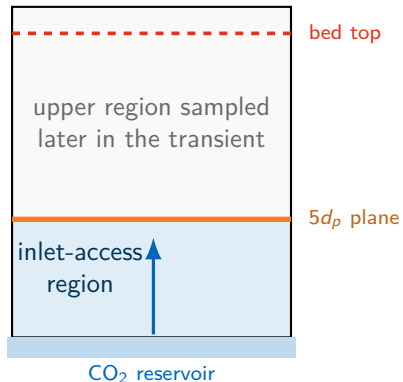
$$D_{\text{eff}} = \arg \min_D \text{NRMSE}(D).$$

The trapezoidal weights  $w_m$  account for unequal time spacing and satisfy  $\sum_m w_m = 1$ .

$D_{\text{access}}$  is cheap because it avoids adsorption dynamics and optimization.



# Why use an interior plane?



## A plane at $5d_p$ includes

- the inlet openings
- second-layer and deeper bottlenecks
- parallel paths connecting inlet to the plane

## The bed top answers a different question

- measure conductance through the entire bed
- include upper bottlenecks not sampled early

The accessibility calculation connects the inlet to an interior plane at a selected depth. It includes every connected path and every bottleneck between these two boundaries. Therefore, a bottleneck in the second layer or any deeper layer below the plane directly reduces  $G_{\text{access}}$ . We use an interior plane because the descriptor targets access from the inlet into the region sampled during the earlier part of adsorption. A plane at the bed top would instead measure steady conductance through the complete bed. It would include upper restrictions that affect the response mainly later in the transient. This does not mean that upper bottlenecks are physically unimportant. It means that whole-bed conductance answers a different question from inlet accessibility. The appropriate depth must therefore be checked rather than assumed.

# Why not predict uptake directly from $G_{\text{access}}$ ?

## Direct endpoint relation

$$G_{\text{access}} \longrightarrow \bar{q}(5000 \text{ s})$$

- strong correlation:  $\rho_s = 0.968$
- ranks beds or predicts one endpoint
- valid at the selected time and conditions

**If only uptake at 5000 s is needed,  $G_{\text{access}}$  is sufficient;  $D_{\text{eff}}$  is needed for a reusable transient model.**

## Transport closure

$$G_{\text{access}} \longrightarrow D_{\text{access}} \longrightarrow D_{\text{eff}} \longrightarrow \bar{q}(t)$$

- generates the complete uptake curve
- retains conservative 1D transport
- gives axial  $c(z, t)$  and  $q(z, t)$  profiles

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└ Numerical methods and diffusivity prediction

└ Why not predict uptake directly from  $G_{\text{access}}$ ?

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Transport closure

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- generates the complete uptake curve
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- gives axial  $c(z, t)$  and  $q(z, t)$  profiles

Accessibility conductance correlates very strongly with uptake at 5000 seconds. If our only task were to rank beds or estimate this one endpoint under the same conditions, we could use  $G_{\text{access}}$  directly.

Our intended reduced model asks for more. We want the complete uptake curve and the axial concentration and loading profiles. The 1D conservation equations require a transport coefficient, which is  $D_{\text{eff}}$ . Furthermore,  $D_{\text{access}}$  should not simply be inserted as  $D_{\text{eff}}$  because the strict proportional model performs substantially worse than the fitted power-law closure. The sequence is therefore: calculate  $D_{\text{access}}$  cheaply, predict  $D_{\text{eff}}$  through the closure, and use  $D_{\text{eff}}$  in the transient 1D model.

**Fit one diffusivity per bed**

1. Choose a trial  $D$  within prescribed bounds.
2. Solve the coupled 1D equations for  $c(z, t)$  and  $q(z, t)$ .
3. Compare mean uptake with the network using time-weighted NRMSE.
4. Use previous errors to select the next  $D$  and repeat (optimization).

**Learn the relationship across beds**

- Pair each fitted  $D_{\text{eff}}$  with its geometry-based  $D_{\text{access}}$ .
- Fit the closure  $D_{\text{eff}} = f(D_{\text{access}})$  on the training beds.
- Leave one bed out to assess diffusivity prediction.

The bounded search operates in  $\log_{10} D$  and starts deterministically.

**Per-bed optimization supplies the targets for closure calibration.**

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Per-bed optimization supplies the targets for closure calibration.

There are two fitting tasks. First, for each bed, optimize one diffusivity to match its network uptake curve. Each trial restarts the coupled transient model from the prescribed initial state. Then learn a relationship between these fitted targets and accessibility across beds. In leave-one-bed-out evaluation, fit that relationship on nineteen beds and predict the twentieth. This is internal validation within the current ensemble.

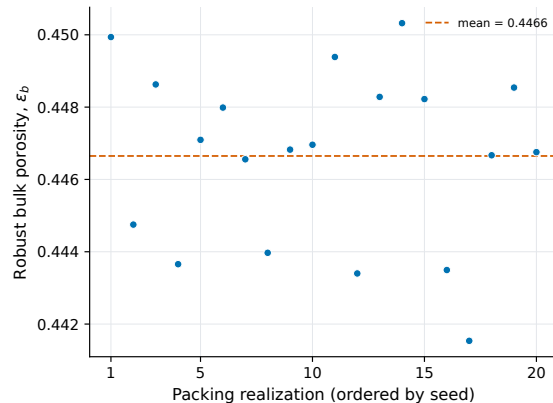
Section 4 of 5

## Results and robustness

Uptake variability, predictive closure and depth sensitivity

Uptake variability, predictive closure and depth sensitivity.

# The twenty beds have nearly equal bulk porosity



**Bulk-porosity CV: 0.55%.**

## Controlled ensemble

- same bead count and diameter
- same tube geometry
- only the insertion seed changes

CV: coefficient of variation

$$CV_{\epsilon} = s_{\epsilon} / \bar{\epsilon}$$

$s_{\epsilon}$ : standard deviation

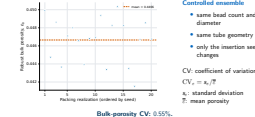
$\bar{\epsilon}$ : mean porosity

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Results and robustness

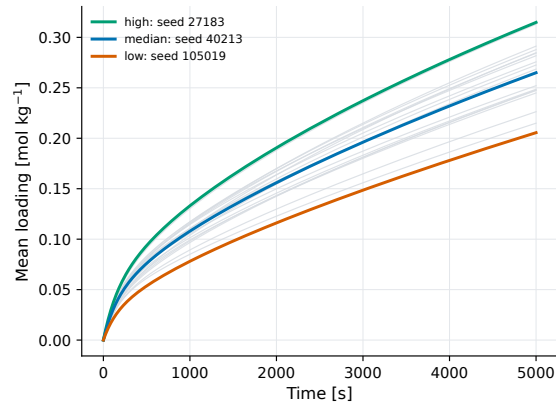
The twenty beds have nearly equal bulk porosity

The twenty beds have nearly equal bulk porosity



The mean bulk porosity is approximately 0.44665. Divide the sample standard deviation by this mean to obtain the coefficient of variation, 0.55 percent. The horizontal axis orders beds by their insertion seed. The small spread establishes the controlled comparison.

# Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves



**At 5000 s: 0.206–0.315 mol kg<sup>-1</sup>, with an uptake CV of 11.0%.**

## Network reference

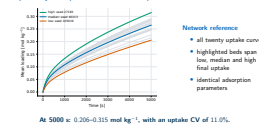
- all twenty uptake curves
- highlighted beds span low, median and high final uptake
- identical adsorption parameters

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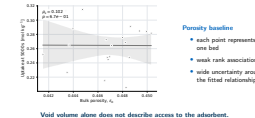
## Results and robustness

Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves

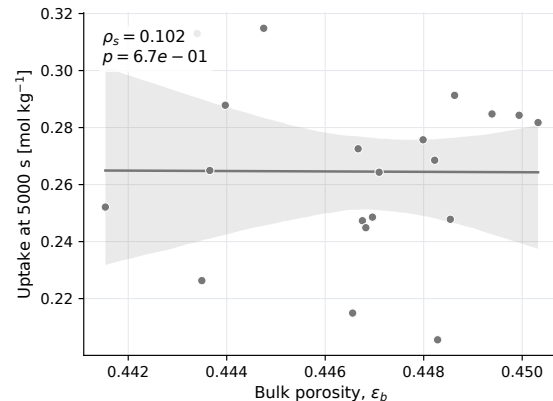
Similar porosity still produces different uptake curves



The pale curves show the full ensemble. Orange, blue and green identify low, median and high final uptake. These representative beds are selected by final uptake, not by accessibility. The uptake varies much more strongly than porosity.



The plot compares bulk porosity with mean loading at 5000 seconds. Spearman correlation is approximately 0.102. The shaded band is pointwise bootstrap uncertainty in the fitted relationship, not a prediction interval for a new bed.

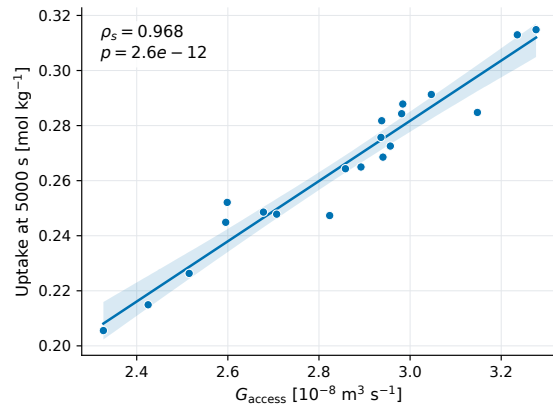


### Porosity baseline

- each point represents one bed
- weak rank association
- wide uncertainty around the fitted relationship

Void volume alone does not describe access to the adsorbent.

# Accessibility explains differences in final uptake



**Inlet-connected pathways explain variability that porosity misses.**

## Steady network descriptor

- $G_{\text{access}}$  measures inlet-to-interior conductance
- greater conductance accompanies greater uptake

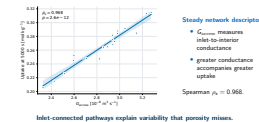
Spearman  $\rho_s = 0.968$ .

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Results and robustness

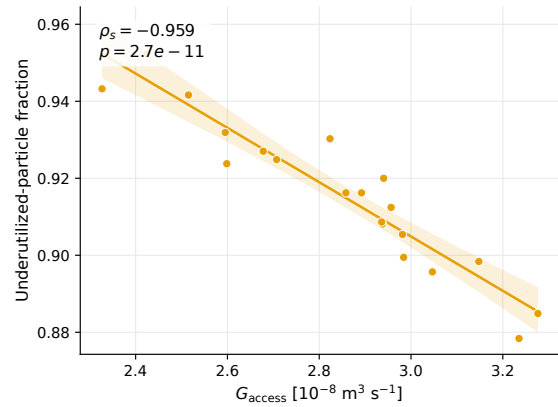
Accessibility explains differences in final uptake

Accessibility explains differences in final uptake



We calculate accessibility using a steady diffusion problem without adsorption. The Spearman coefficient is 0.968. More accessible beds generally have greater uptake. This is a within-ensemble association. The shaded band represents uncertainty in the fitted relationship.

# Greater accessibility reduces particle underutilization



Higher  $G_{\text{access}}$  accompanies fewer underutilized particles.

## Underutilized fraction

$$f_{\text{under}} = \frac{1}{N_p} \sum_{k=1}^{N_p} I_k.$$

$I_k = 1$  when

$$q_k(t_f) < 0.5q^*(p_{\text{inlet}}).$$

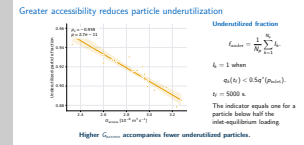
$t_f = 5000 \text{ s.}$

The indicator equals one for a particle below half the inlet-equilibrium loading.

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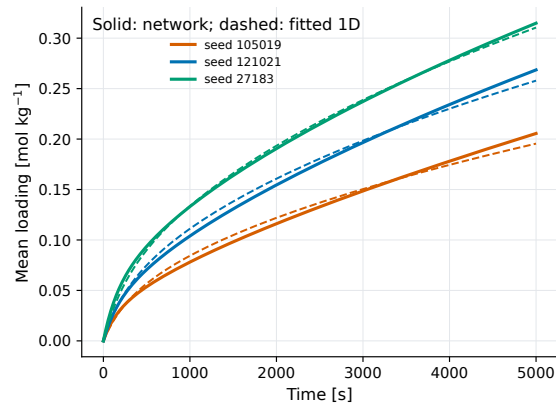
Results and robustness

Greater accessibility reduces particle underutilization



For each bead we compare its final loading with half the equilibrium loading at the inlet pressure. The indicator is one below this threshold and zero otherwise. Averaging over particles gives the plotted fraction. This is a threshold-based utilization measure, not the fraction of completely inaccessible particles.

# One fitted $D_{\text{eff}}$ reproduces each uptake curve



Across twenty beds, the mean fitted-curve NRMSE is 1.58%.

## Per-bed optimization

1. solve the 1D model for a trial  $D$
2. evaluate time-weighted NRMSE against the network curve
3. use previous errors to select the next  $D$  and repeat (optimization)

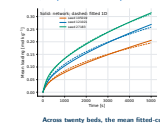
Solid: network.  
Dashed: fitted 1D model.

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## Results and robustness

One fitted  $D_{\text{eff}}$  reproduces each uptake curve

One fitted  $D_{\text{eff}}$  reproduces each uptake curve



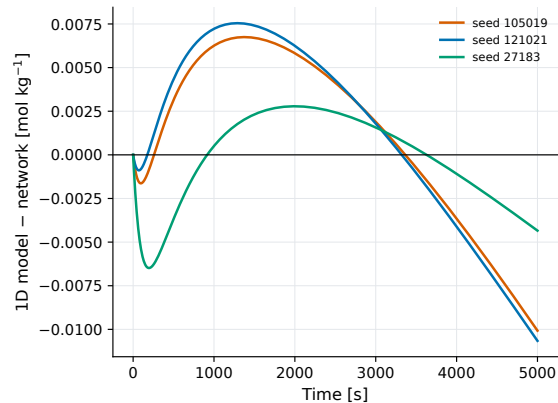
Per-bed optimization

1. solve the 1D model for a trial  $D$
2. evaluate time-weighted NRMSE against the network curve
3. use previous errors to select the next  $D$  and repeat (optimization)

Solid: network.  
Dashed: fitted 1D model.

For each bed, the transient pore-network calculation provides a reference uptake curve. We repeatedly solve the 1D model with trial diffusivities and minimize the time-weighted normalized root-mean-square error. The bounded optimizer searches in  $\log_{10} D$ . Its initial trial follows from the prescribed bounds, without random sampling. Previous objective values guide subsequent trials until the search meets its tolerance. Each trial solves both coupled equations from the same initial state. The optimized diffusivity is  $D_{\text{eff}}$ . This figure shows per-bed fits, not predictions for unseen beds. The mean error is 1.58 percent.

## Residuals show the remaining reduction error



**Time-weighted NRMSE across all beds: 0.84–2.46%.**

### Curve residual

$$e(t) = \bar{q}_{1D}(t) - \bar{q}_{PNM}(t).$$

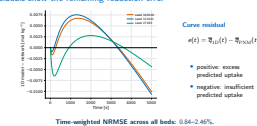
- positive: excess predicted uptake
- negative: insufficient predicted uptake

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Results and robustness

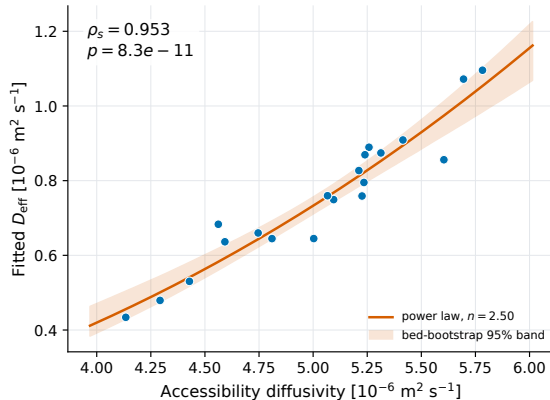
Residuals show the remaining reduction error

Residuals show the remaining reduction error



The same three representative beds appear here. The residual is the 1D mean loading minus the network mean loading. Its sign changes over time, showing that one coefficient cannot reproduce every detail. NRMSE summarizes the full residual curve using trapezoidal time weights and normalizes by final network loading.

# A positive power law relates accessibility to diffusivity



The fitted exponent is  $n \approx 2.50$  for this ensemble.

## Selected closure

$$\frac{D_{\text{eff}}}{D_m} = C \left( \frac{D_{\text{access}}}{D_m} \right)^n$$

$$D_{\text{access}} = \frac{G_{\text{access}} H}{A_{\text{tube}}}$$

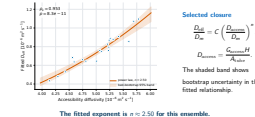
The shaded band shows bootstrap uncertainty in the fitted relationship.

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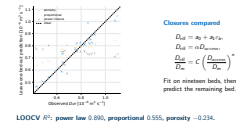
## Results and robustness

A positive power law relates accessibility to diffusivity

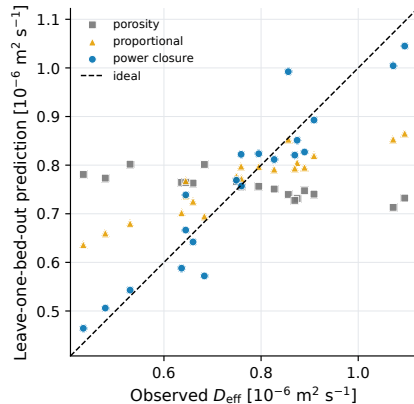
A positive power law relates accessibility to diffusivity



Each bed supplies a geometrically calculated accessibility diffusivity and a diffusivity fitted to its transient response. The power law relates them. This plot shows the fit to the complete ensemble. The band is pointwise bootstrap uncertainty in the relationship, not an individual-bed prediction interval. The exponent is specific to the studied conditions.



# The closure predicts diffusivity for a withheld bed



## Closures compared

$$D_{\text{eff}} = a_0 + a_1 \varepsilon_b,$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = \alpha D_{\text{access}},$$

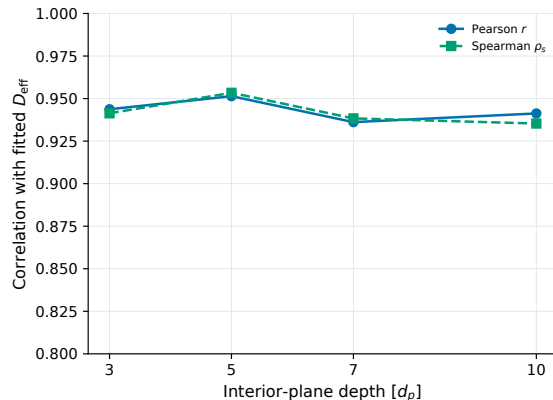
$$\frac{D_{\text{eff}}}{D_m} = C \left( \frac{D_{\text{access}}}{D_m} \right)^n.$$

Fit on nineteen beds, then predict the remaining bed.

**LOOCV  $R^2$ : power law 0.890, proportional 0.555, porosity -0.234.**

We leave out one entire bed, fit each closure to the other nineteen, and predict the omitted diffusivity. Repeating this gives twenty held-out predictions. Blue circles show the power law, orange triangles show proportionality, and grey squares show porosity. Model form and diagnostic depth were compared within this ensemble, so these scores remain internal validation.

# Accessibility remains correlated across diagnostic depths



**Both correlations remain high across the tested depths.**

## Depth sensitivity

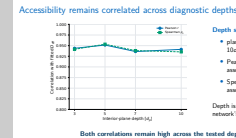
- planes at 3, 5, 7 and  $10d_p$
- Pearson: linear association
- Spearman: rank association

Depth is measured above each network's lowest pore.

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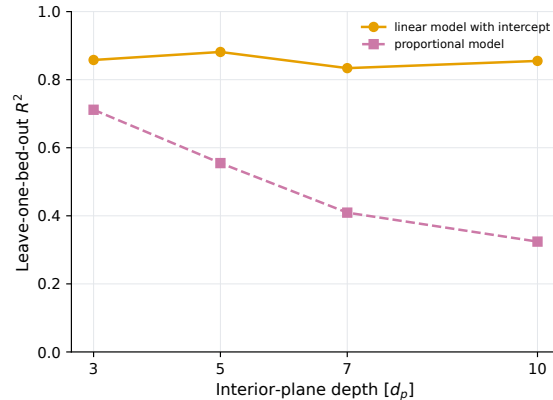
Results and robustness

Accessibility remains correlated across diagnostic depths



The original descriptor places the diagnostic plane above the lowest pore in each network. We tested three, five, seven and ten particle diameters using that convention. Both linear and rank correlations remain high. These depths are not measured exactly from the physical bed bottom.

# Predictive performance is stable across diagnostic depths



## Models in this comparison

- linear model with intercept

$$D_{\text{eff}} = aD_{\text{access}} + b$$

- proportional model

$$D_{\text{eff}} = \alpha D_{\text{access}}$$

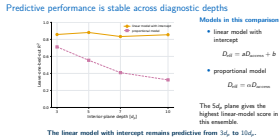
The  $5d_p$  plane gives the highest linear-model score in this ensemble.

**The linear model with intercept remains predictive from  $3d_p$  to  $10d_p$ .**

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Results and robustness

Predictive performance is stable across diagnostic depths



This plot compares affine and proportional closures at each depth. It does not plot the power-law score. Five particle diameters gives the best linear-model score among these tested depths. This sensitivity supports the association while independent beds are still needed to evaluate model and depth selection.

Section 5 of 5

## Conclusions and next steps

What the evidence supports and what remains to validate

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# What the present evidence establishes

## Supported

- porosity alone misses important packing variability
- inlet-connected topology controls transient utilization
- one  $D_{\text{eff}}$  reproduces each detailed curve accurately
- $D_{\text{access}}$  provides an interpretable predictive closure

## Not yet claimed

- industrial breakthrough performance
- effects of flow, heat or water competition
- transfer to other bead sizes or  $D_{\text{tube}}/d_p$
- a universal power-law exponent

**The contribution is a structure-to-model closure for a controlled diffusion-driven adsorption problem.**

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└ Conclusions and next steps

└ What the present evidence establishes

What the present evidence establishes

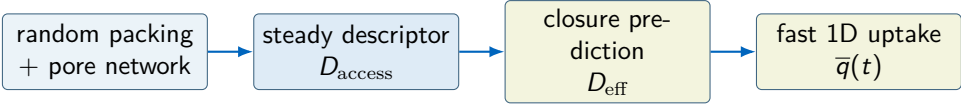
| Supported                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Not yet claimed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• porosity alone misses important packing variability</li> <li>• inlet-connected topology controls transient utilization</li> <li>• one <math>D_{\text{eff}}</math> reproduces each detailed curve accurately</li> <li>• <math>D_{\text{access}}</math> provides an interpretable predictive closure</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• industrial breakthrough performance</li> <li>• effects of flow, heat or water competition</li> <li>• transfer to other bead sizes or <math>D_{\text{tube}}/d_p</math></li> <li>• a universal power-law exponent</li> </ul> |

The contribution is a structure-to-model closure for a controlled diffusion-driven adsorption problem.

The present evidence supports four conclusions. Bulk porosity misses important differences among random packings. Inlet-connected topology explains a large part of the resulting variation. One optimized  $D_{\text{eff}}$  allows the 1D model to reproduce each detailed uptake curve accurately. Finally,  $D_{\text{access}}$  provides a cheap and interpretable input for predicting that coefficient. The scope must remain clear. We have not modelled an industrial breakthrough column with imposed flow. We have not included heat effects, water or competitive adsorption. We also have not demonstrated that the fitted power law transfers to other bead sizes or tube-to-particle ratios. The result is a validated structure-to-model closure for this controlled, diffusion-driven adsorption problem, rather than a universal adsorption correlation.

# Pore accessibility retains what bulk porosity loses

**Equal void volume does not imply equal transport. How that void space connects to the inlet matters.**



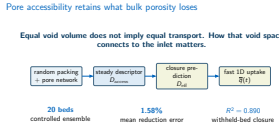
**20 beds**  
controlled ensemble

**1.58%**  
mean reduction error

**$R^2 = 0.890$**   
withheld-bed closure

2026-09-12

- Conclusions and next steps
- Pore accessibility retains what bulk porosity loses



The main message is that equal void volume does not imply equal transport. How the void space connects to the inlet matters. Starting from a random packing, we extract the pore network and calculate the steady accessibility descriptor. The fitted closure converts this descriptor into  $D_{\text{eff}}$ , and the conservative 1D model uses that coefficient to predict the transient uptake. Across twenty controlled beds, porosity varied by only 0.55 percent while uptake varied much more strongly. The optimized 1D model reproduced the pore-network curves with a mean NRMSE of 1.58 percent. The accessibility power law achieved a leave-one-bed-out  $R^2$  of 0.890. The practical outcome is therefore a fast transient model that retains a clear and measurable link to the underlying packing structure.

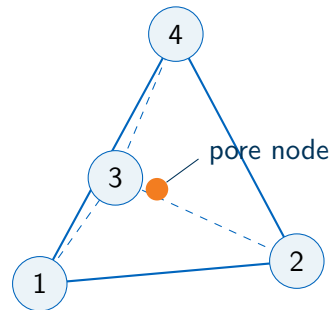
Backup slides

## How the pore network is constructed

Particle geometry, Sobol volume allocation and transport

These supplementary slides explain the construction in the code. The sketches illustrate the method and are not extracted simulation geometries.

# 1. Particle positions define candidate pore nodes



Schematic 3D projection  
Bead centres form a tetrahedron

- Start with known bead centres, radii and bed boundaries.
- Delaunay tetrahedralization groups neighbouring centres into sets of four.
- Locate the circumcentre: the point equidistant from those four centres.
- Retain valid points inside the bed and outside the solid as pore nodes.

A node represents a gas region. Its volume is assigned later.

**The particle geometry determines where the pore nodes are placed.**

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Backup: pore-network construction

1. Particle positions define candidate pore nodes

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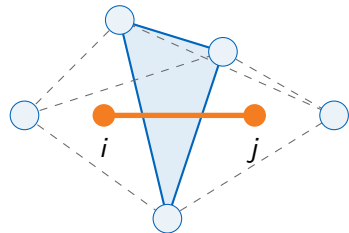
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A node represents a gas region. Its volume is assigned later.

The particle geometry determines where the pore nodes are placed.

Our beads have equal radii, so ordinary Delaunay geometry is used. The sketch is a projected tetrahedron. Its drawn pore marker is illustrative. The actual code computes each circumcentre in three dimensions, rejects singular tetrahedra and checks the point against the bed domain and bead surfaces. A pore node is a representative location rather than a reconstructed cavity surface.

## 2. Shared particle faces define pore connections



Two tetrahedra share three beads  
Schematic 3D projection

- Two neighbouring tetrahedra share a triangular face.
- The three beads around that face define an opening.
- A valid opening connects pore nodes  $i$  and  $j$  through a throat.
- Estimate throat length  $L_{ij}$  and circular area  $A_{ij}$  from geometry.

$$G_{ij} = D_m \frac{A_{ij}}{L_{ij}}.$$

**At this stage we know the nodes and connections. Sobol sampling has not been used.**

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

└ 2. Shared particle faces define pore connections

The code uses shared Delaunay faces to identify candidate throats. Length is the distance between pore nodes. The throat radius is approximated by the shared-face circumradius minus the bead radius, and the area by pi times radius squared. Closed or degenerate connections are rejected. This circular opening is a modelling approximation, not the exact three-sphere aperture.

2. Shared particle faces define pore connections



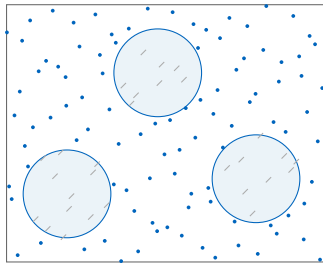
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At this stage we know the nodes and connections. Sobol sampling has not been used.

### 3. Sobol points measure the gas space



Illustrative 2D Sobol sample

Blue: gas points; grey crosses: solid points

- Distribute  $2^{22} \approx 4.2$  million sample points through the cylindrical bed.
- Sobol sampling covers the domain with few gaps and clusters.
- Check each point against the bead surfaces.
- Discard points inside solid particles and retain gas-space points.

These are measuring points, not extra pores or mesh cells.

**Sobol sampling estimates volume. It does not generate network connections.**

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└ Backup: pore-network construction

└ 3. Sobol points measure the gas space

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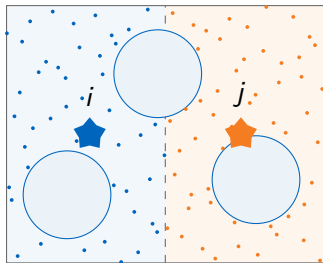
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Sobol sampling estimates volume. It does not generate network connections.

The actual code generates a scrambled three-dimensional Sobol sequence and maps it uniformly into the cylinder. The sketch uses a two-dimensional Sobol sequence only to explain solid versus void classification. The points do not carry concentration or take part in the time integration. Increasing the sample count improves the volume estimates while leaving the geometry-derived graph unchanged.

## 4. Assign gas-space samples to the nearest pore



Two illustrative pore nodes  
Each gas point takes its nearest node's colour

- Assign every retained gas point to its nearest pore node.
- Count the assigned points:  $N_i$  for pore  $i$ .
- A larger count gives a larger share of the calculated void volume.

$$V_i = V_{\text{void}} \frac{N_i + 0.5}{\sum_j (N_j + 0.5)}.$$

- The small 0.5 correction prevents zero volumes.
- Normalization ensures  $\sum_i V_i = V_{\text{void}}$ .

**The total volume is conserved, while each individual pore volume is an estimate.**

### 4. Assign gas-space samples to the nearest pore

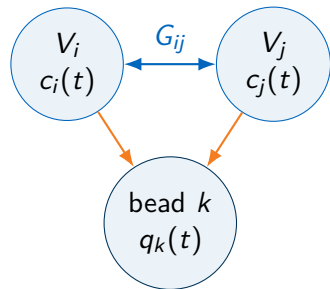
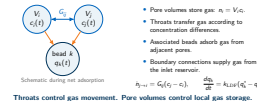


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- The small 0.5 correction prevents zero volumes.
- Normalization ensures  $\sum_i V_i = V_{\text{void}}$ .

The total volume is conserved, while each individual pore volume is an estimate.

The dashed line illustrates a nearest-node partition for two nodes in two dimensions. The actual allocation uses all retained nodes in three dimensions and Euclidean nearest-neighbour distances. Total void volume is calculated independently from cylinder volume minus the calculated solid volume within the bed bounds. It is not taken directly from the fraction of Sobol points in gas. Normalization fixes the total but does not prove the local volumes are exact or boundary-conforming.



Schematic during net adsorption

- Pore volumes store gas:  $n_i = V_i c_i$ .
- Throats transfer gas according to concentration differences.
- Associated beads adsorb gas from adjacent pores.
- Boundary connections supply gas from the inlet reservoir.

$$\dot{n}_{j \rightarrow i} = G_{ij}(c_j - c_i), \quad \frac{dq_k}{dt} = k_{LDF}(q_k^* - q_k).$$

**Throats control gas movement. Pore volumes control local gas storage.**

The particle-pore association comes from the tetrahedral geometry. Once geometry, volumes and boundary conditions are known, the solver advances pore concentrations and bead loadings together. Gas removed by adsorption is added to the solid inventory. During desorption the exchange reverses. This construction describes the gas space between beads; bead uptake kinetics represent the internal adsorption process.